

Power to the PATIENT

An assertive new age patient is demanding new services, rules and sometimes even treatments



ETHICS & MEDICS

In an attempt to stem corruption in the medical profession, the Medical Council of India (MCI) has come up with a new code of conduct for doctors. No medical practitioner will be allowed to receive gifts, cash or monetary grants, accept tours, paid vacations or any hospitality from pharmaceutical or healthcare companies under any pretext. Nor will they be allowed to endorse any drug or product publicly. They may, however, work for pharmaceutical and allied healthcare industries in advisory capacity. A timely and welcome move. But exactly how does the MCI propose to supervise lakhs of doctors spread across the country?

62%

INDIANS COME TO A DOCTOR PREPARED WITH A DIAGNOSIS OF THEIR OWN.

More Than Just Pill Counters

To a consumer of medicine, chemists are a lifeline—the first port of call after the doctor. The just-concluded survey by the Delhi Pharmaceutical Trust in Delhi and Bangalore shows that people expect a lot more from chemists than just medicine. The wishlist of patients as consumers throws up a few surprises:



Home delivery of medicines/ telephonic orders.



Arrange for a medicine within a short time if it's not in stock.

Provide basic services like checking BP, temperature, first aid, injection etc.



Provide basic medical or pathological tests like urine, blood sugar etc.

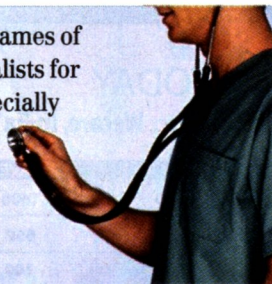


Verify the correct name of medicine from the prescribing doctor if not clear to the chemist.

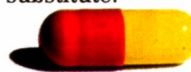


Put a mechanism in place to ensure that the key person in the shop can be identified easily.

Recommend names of reputed specialists for a disease, especially when such doctors are not available in the area.



Take consent from the doctor on phone, if a medicine is not available, before giving a substitute.



Sell in small quantities and give credit if necessary.

Painful Truth: Injecting Expectations

Patient power might be the buzzword, but it can cut both ways. Consider a 2009 survey by PGIMER, Chandigarh, on safe injection practices. As many as 36 per cent doctors reported that patient expectation, rather than rational protocols, often drove them to prescribe injections over oral medication. And over 78 per cent said that patients got "psychological relief" from injections. At a time when experts feel that injection usage in India is believed to be way over the desired level (with each individual getting six a year on average), the figures are alarming, especially those related to risk of infections, unsafe practices and biomedical wastes.



■ Compiled by Damayanti Datta